

refused to admit that the police are playing favourites. "The NDA Government does not give protection to anyone involved in criminal cases. We do not patronise criminals. The impressive conviction rate is a testimony to this," says Modi.

However, he can do better by sparing a look at the following instances. In January this year, an FIR—filed by a construction firm Gammon India Ltd—was lodged against Bablu for allegedly demanding Rs 9 lakh as extortion money. The construction firm is one of the group of companies that is trying to connect Silchar in Assam to Porbandar in Gujarat through an expressway. Bablu, who represents the Raghupur constituency in the state's Supaul district, however, denies the charges and claims it is a "political conspiracy to discredit him."

This is just the tip of the iceberg. Last year in September, an FIR was lodged against Jai Kumar and his



PAST MASTERS: The new dons are filling the space left by Shahabuddin (left) and Pappu Yadav supporters for assaulting the Managing Director of the Bihar Land Development Bank. Jai Kumar, who was earlier accused in an abduction case, denies the charges.

A few months earlier, an FIR was lodged against Patel for demanding extortion money from a company making stone chips for road construction in the state's Sheikhpura district. Patel too had alleged political conspiracy.

Earlier, Pandey (now suspended) had landed behind bars after he allegedly demanded money from a company engaged in rural electrification in Aurangabad and had threatened to kill the manager. He was again in the news when he "threatened to eliminate" Sasaram jail superintendent Sanjay Kumar Choudhary. Pandey was then shifted to Buxar jail after Choudhary lodged an

FIR against him. In September last year, a local court had to acquit him in three cases owing to lack of evidence. It is said that the police officers, who were listed as witnesses for the prosecution, had failed to turn up. And it is by sweet coincidence that almost all of these cases have remained "under investigation" due to lack of follow-up reports by the state police.

If this is what the state administration means by *sushasan*, one dreads to think what *dushasan* (bad governance) may mean. ■



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